

Thanksgiving Weekend 2010

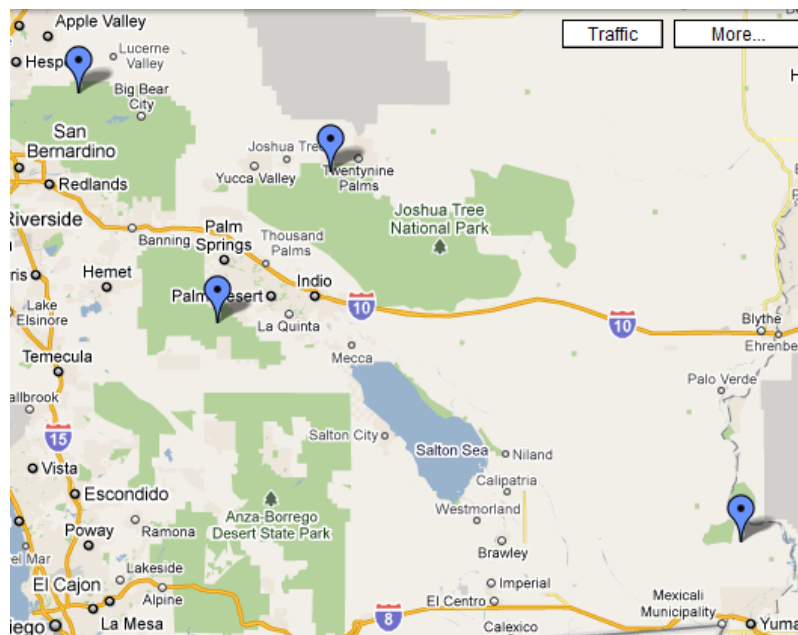
Local Mountains, Yuma, Indian Cove in Joshua Tree, High Desert Emergency Room...

For various reasons I was unable to leave town to be with family for Thanksgiving which left me with 4 whole days where I would be in the Southern California area and wasn't otherwise committed. This is unusual.

I had recovered (mostly) from the flu I was suffering from the previous weekend no doubt aided by the 20+ mile day hike of Telescope (11,043 ft) from Scotty's Well (-250 ft). As a result I was barely coughing at all.

I briefly contemplated sitting at home and maybe watching TV but then decided to run out and get some peaks.

I covered a bit of ground.



Thursday – In Which Matt Hikes Alone

Butterfly Peak (6240'), Lion Peak (6868'), Pyramid Peak (7035'), Pine Mountain #2 (7054')

<http://www.flickr.com/photos/matthewhengst/sets/72157625344797311/with/5208590856/>

The local Hundred Peaks Section of the Sierra Club has a list of 270+ peaks stretching from San Diego to the southern Sierra almost all of which are done as short day hikes. A few years back I was climbing them every weekend but after getting hooked on the Sierra and desert areas I'd been sitting at 91 HPS peaks for months.

The section recognizes 100, 200, and list completion which make for good short term goals. I resolved this weekend I would try and get myself over the 100 mark.

As Thursday was Thanksgiving my options for company on the trail were rather limited and with the snow level somewhere between 6,000 and 7,000 ft my options were further restricted unless I wanted to break out the snowshoes.

I decided to head back out to the desert divide area south of San Jacinto where I could pick up 4-6 peaks depending on how the day went. So, I woke up several hours before dawn and set out for the 3+ hour drive to south desert divide near Anza.



After finding the trailhead (which was just an intersection in a neighborhood of horse properties) I parked where I hoped my vehicle wouldn't be ticketed (or shot at, you never know up there) and set out along an old trail / dirt road.



Some rather energetic dogs chased me along the fence line but soon I was up in the hills where I'd see no sign of another human being all day.



The terrain was the usual mix of rocks and shrubs that makes up so much of the area between San Diego and Orange County.



See, I told you they like to shoot things up there...

The trail meandered through hilly terrain which was littered with the occasional bit of mine equipment. I made pretty good time until I came across something interesting.



An open and uncollapsed mine entrance. I've come across a number of mines on my various peak trips but generally they are either locked behind gates or the roof has collapsed not far in. This particularly mine was wide open.



I did the only logical thing and went inside. Immediately the temperature shot up and my glasses and camera lens fogged up due to the humidity. While I waited for that to subside and for my eyes to adjust to the darkness I dug out my headlamp so I could see further in. The floor had a few inches of standing water which could be avoided by balancing somewhat precariously on some very rusty pipes.



I was able to get in about 30 feet before I would have had to start wading through some rather nasty looking ankle deep water. As I was in my very non-waterproof light hikers and I had a long potentially

very cold day I decided to leave it for another day and headed back outside into the cold wind.



I soon found the rather well maintained Prospector's Trail and headed up toward the first peak, Butterfly.



The trail lasted until just shy of the summit ridge and it was about at this point I started to find snow on the ground. I had been concerned about the amount of snow I might find higher up but so far it was limited to an annoyance as partially melted snow was transferring from the brush soaking through my hiking pants.



I made the peak and took a brief minute or two to take pictures and grab a bite to eat. (I'd forgotten about my headlamp after leaving the mine)

My plan was to head down the eastern slope of the ridge and pick up with a jeep trail I could take over to an eventual junction with the Pacific Crest Trail. After a false start that ended rather abruptly in an impassable wall of brush I was able to drop off the ridge and eventually made it to a very deteriorated jeep trail.



The jeep road dropped down to an open area with an abandoned corral and some random fencing. From here I started climbing up a gradual canyon until I eventually joined with the Pacific Crest Trail. Here the trail became more established.

As I picked my way along the eastern slope of the divide I started finding much more snow on the ground and was slammed by a constant cold wind. I quickly donned my long underwear bottoms and rain jacket and pushed on.



The wind had left ice deposited on most of the plants facing Azusa and it was quite pretty though ducking under some of the heavily iced branches while wind gusts caused everything to sway wildly was somewhat precarious and I did miss getting hit by sizable ice balls once or twice.

The second peak of the day, Lion, was just a short diversion off the trail up a NE facing slope.



There was plenty of snow covering the ground but it was cold enough it didn't soak my boots. I even found the occasional trail duck along the way to let me know I was heading up the right peak.

I made the somewhat less than impressive summit and after poking around in the snow found a soaking wet peak register. No signing in for me.

Dropping back down the ridge I checked my iPhone and found I was actually getting periodic reception. This let me check in with a few folks and wish them a happy Thanksgiving / let them know I was still alive.

Further up the trail I came to the area between Pyramid and Pine. This was the furthest out I'd be for the day and I decided to do the further Pyramid first.



I left the trail and picked my way up a ridge covered in icy shrubs and before long hopped over a few ice covered rocks to the summit cairn. Again there was a register but it was soaked through.

Three peaks down and I was hopeful I could still make one of my optional peaks (Ken or Rock Point) on the way back. I hurried down the ridge and started SE along a fairly clear ridge.



Unfortunately that didn't last long. I dropped off the ridge following a marked use trail (well, hole in the 10+ ft brush) only to come to an all but impassable section. I had to batter my way through and eventually work my way back up to the ridge off to my left.

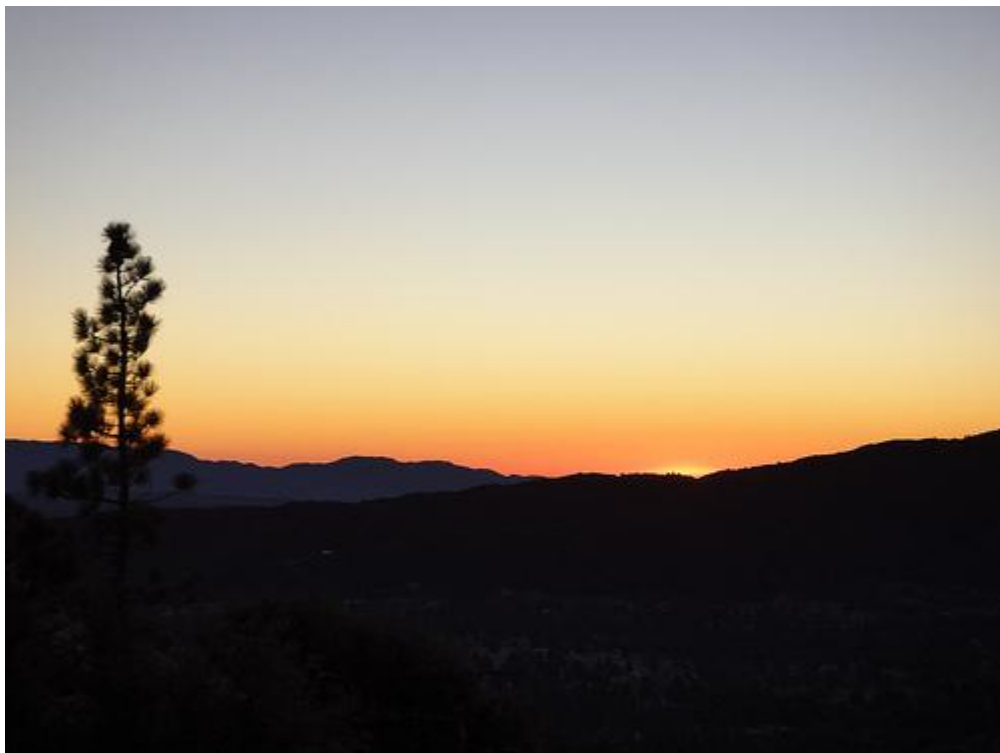
From here I followed a fairly well ducked trail that meandered through the brush and rocks. At times I had to cling to branches to make it up short icy sections and more than once I took a false trail and had to backtrack.

I eventually made the summit after gingerly climbing over some very slick and icy rocks.



With some relief I backtracked, staying on the ridge the entire time this time and soon found myself back on the trail though several hours later than I would have liked.

I turned back towards the trailhead eyeing the sun and while I'd hoped to make either Ken or Rock Point that afternoon it soon became readily apparent I'd be lucky to make the cars before dark. I had to hustle to make it back through the cross country section before the sun went down.



I made it back to my vehicle about an hour after dark having done a fair amount of mileage for the day. Sadly with 4 peaks down in order to meet my goal for the two days I'd need to do 5 peaks Friday.

It was a long drive back to my apartment and a rather short night in bed.

Friday – In Which We Drive More Than We Hike

White Mountain #1 (7727'), Rattlesnake Mountain (6131'), Luna Mountain (5967'), Round Mountain (5272'), and (bleh) Bailey Peak (5699')
<http://www.flickr.com/photos/matthewhengst/sets/72157625372208997/>

After a few brief hours of sleep I rolled out of bed at an unpleasant hour Friday morning, tossed everything back into my vehicle, and drove out to a local carpool point to meet John Slagle, Mark Butski, and Christine Soskins at 4:30 am. *Yawn*

The peaks for today were all to the north of Big Bear accessed via long dirt roads out of Hesperia. We'd picked the area due to the fact several of us hadn't done these particular peaks, they were low enough we might not run into problematic snow, and we could do enough in a day to give me a shot at finishing up my 100 peaks emblem.

The four of us loaded up in my Rav4 and headed north on the 15. We exited the freeway at Hesperia and after a brief gas station stop (I needed food as my apartment is rather barren due to work travel) we started down the first in a very long series of dirt roads.

We headed for White Mountain first as it was the furthest in and the highest peak of the day figuring if we could make that the others should follow rather easily. Also the temperature along the way had dipped into the teens at times and we were all hoping it would warm up a bit.

We made the trailhead for White without major mishap though there was about an inch of snow on the road in places and plenty of iced over puddles for me to drive through.







Views weren't bad but the hike to the summit was just a few miles of eroded jeep roads. The summit itself looked to have been visited by jeepers more than hikers based on the register. In addition to the booklet and the usual business cards someone had left hand sanitizer and an unused condom. Well that's different...



(And here you see John trying to get his face out of the picture with said condom. Hurray for the wide angle lens!)

Some of the other peaks were just nondescript bumps not far off the dirt road. We hoofed up each one commenting on how much longer it took to drive between the peaks than to actually hike them.





Typical of jeep areas we saw several signs peppered with bullet holes and countless shells scattered around on the ground.



We finished the last of the 4 and were headed back out by early afternoon. I had to get back at a decent hour that night in order to meet Jack and drive out to Yuma (~300 miles) for a peak the following day but rather than be sitting at 99 peaks we decided we'd detour on the way home and pick up the newest addition to the Hundred Peaks list, Bailey.

Uggghhh.

9.9 miles of less than wonderful dirt road so you can park and run 100 feet up a small hill and sign in on a "summit" in the middle of a pile of brush.





During the long drive down we were all in agreement we'd just as soon see the peak delisted along with the other drive-up's in the area. Sadly for some reason the section voted a week later to re-add the delisted peaks so there'd be a reason to drive up there. I can only believe it was because many of them had already done the drive and wanted to share the pain.

It was getting dark as we finally made it off the dirt road below Bailey and back on the pavement. Several hours later we arrived back in Orange County and after dropping the others off at the rideshare I drove directly over to Jack Kieffer's where I begged use of a shower and transferred all my car camping and hiking gear into Jack's truck.

We left late and had a good 300 miles to drive. Oddly enough not long after we got on the road I used my phone to post to Facebook about being on the way to climb Picacho and almost immediately received a call from Paul Garry. He had intended to do another pair of desert peaks that weekend but after hearing where we were headed decided this might be more fun. He quickly changed his plans and headed out to meet us.

I'm sorry to say I wasn't much use for a good chunk of the drive. I fell asleep someplace past Oceanside and didn't wake up until El Centro or so. Jack did a noble job of driving us out to Yuma where we found a pull off point near the correct area and were both asleep as quickly as we could lay out our bags.

Saturday – Is A Painters Ladder Considered 6th Class?

“Little” Picacho (1920') 6th class DPS peak

<http://www.flickr.com/photos/matthewhengst/sets/72157625372292559/>



We had decided not to get up until dawn to give ourselves a few more precious hours of sleep and when I reluctantly rolled out of my bag I found Paul had indeed found us sometime the previous night.

I tossed my sleeping bag back in Jack's truck and the three of us went through our morning rituals (coffee and pop tarts are a climbers best friends) and headed off across the desert.



The peak wasn't hard to pick out as it has a pretty unique look. Once we came out of the canyon where we'd parked it was just a matter of heading across the desert to pass around its left side.





Of course we were doing the slightly longer of the two routes listed in the Desert Peaks guide.



The fun didn't really start until we'd looped around the backside and headed for a notch. We now had some light 3rd class mixed in.





The guide basically identified four obstacles: a small ladder, a three foot jump across, a taller ladder, and a false summit block.



The first ladder was, well, a ladder. Bit silly it was there actually as you could scramble up the short bit of rock quite easily to the side. Ah well.



The jump across was slightly more adventurous as there was a 20+ foot drop if you happened to fall down the gap.



I jumped across then pulled out one of my ropes and set up a belay for Paul and Jack. Those are my feet on the right side of the picture.



Finding the route between these obstacles was obviously a challenge...



The second ladder was actually one of the sketchiest moves of the day as the thing moved and was positioned next to a bit of a drop. It would have been quite difficult to make it up that section without the ladder as there was a good 15 ft of overhung rock with no obvious route up.

Once up that we followed a ramp and popped up on the summit ridge.



Now we could see both the summit and the last obstacle, the false summit.



It was the most challenging and fun section of the day. Basically I did an easy 4th class scramble up one side and used a pair of bolts up top to set a top rope for the other two to climb up. On the far side there were another set of bolts where we set another rope and rappelled down to a small ledge.



Easy stuff.



The register itself was actually cemented into the rock and there were a number of booklets.



And a smoke grenade. *shrug*



Jack reliving his military days.



The view was spectacular and it was only late morning. We spent the better part of an hour at the summit enjoying the view, taking pictures, and posting on Facebook from Paul's phone.

Now we had to reverse course over the summit block. As we'd left the first rope in place it was the perfect opportunity to show Jack how to prussic up a rope. Nothing like learning by doing.



Once up we pulled the rope and had an easy rap back down the far side.



From there it was just a matter of following the arrows in the opposite direction.





Hiking back towards the cars we took a slight detour and ran through a neat looking mini slot canyon.



It was mid afternoon by the time we made the cars and after some discussion we decided to drive into Yuma and find some food.

Paul was headed to try and bag Indianhead the following day while Jack and I were going to drive a few hundred miles to Indian Cove in Joshua Tree to run a private rock climbing day on Sunday.

So, after a surprisingly good dinner at a small Mexican food restaurant we said goodbye and took off in different directions.

We had another late night drive but this time I helped out and drove a good chunk of the way as we cut through Joshua Tree National Park.

Oddly enough I was pulled over by a park ranger because I forgot to turn my brights down when I drove past him but he just warned me to turn them down.

We arrive in Joshua Tree city late and pulled into an unofficial bivy spot I'd heard about. The wind was blowing so hard my attempt to set up my tent was pointless and I left Jack to sleep in his truck and crawled under an overhanging rock to try and sleep .

Sunday – Note To Self: In The Contest of Butt v. Rock, Rock Always Wins

Indian Cove, Joshua Tree

<http://www.flickr.com/photos/matthewhengst/sets/72157625497520874/>



We woke up the next morning and had plenty of time to load up and get breakfast before meeting the group of friends at 8 am.



We stopped by a local restaurant called Crossroads for coffee and a very low calorie breakfast...

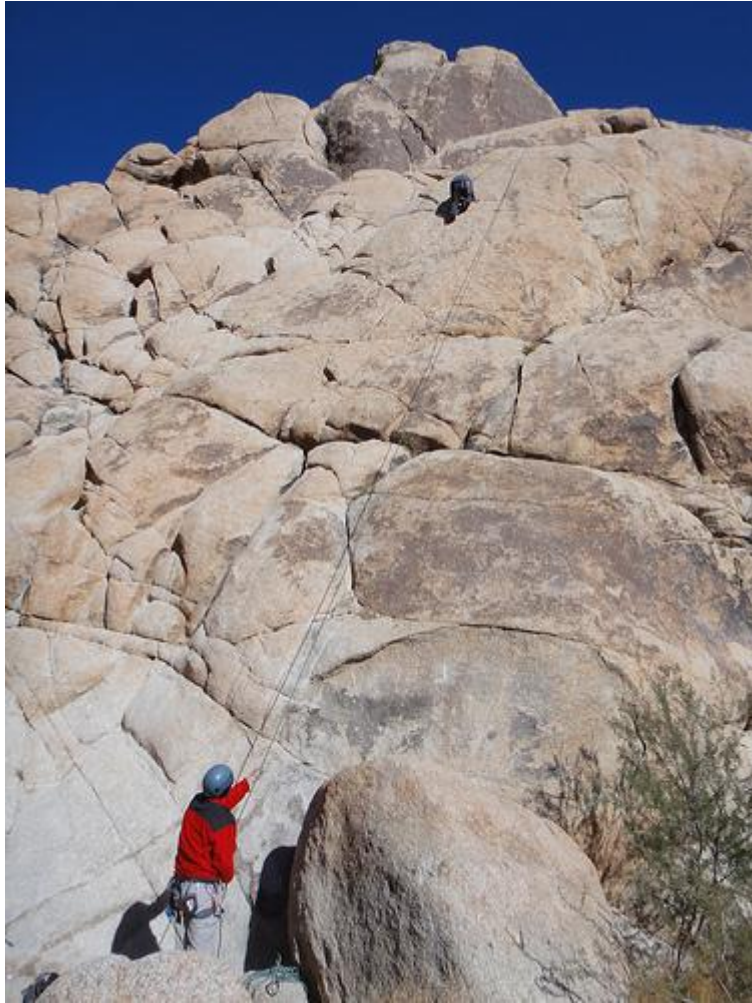


Everyone eventually arrived and a group of us climbed up on the rock to put up some ropes.





When we were done those who wanted to rappelled down to the others below.





And in between climbs we took it easy and chatted.



2 pm rolled around and while one person had to leave the rest of us were still up for some climbing. I grabbed a rope and two folks and we went around the rock to where I'd seen some bolts.

I hadn't really been able to climb all day since most of the time was spent setting ropes and letting the others get some time on the rocks so I was itching to get on something interesting.

The start was rather awkward due to needing to span over from another rock to clip the first bolt. The second was several feet above that and once on the rock I quickly moved up and prepared to clip.

Unfortunately when I went to clip into the second bolt I moved a bit too fast in my haste to get into a position where I was protected. As a result I came off the rock with no warning at about the worst point possible as the belayer had let out slack in preparation for me clipping.

When you take a fall on lead you fall twice the height you are above the last piece of protection plus any slack. As I was only on the second bolt and on a stretchy rope I would have just fallen to the ground and probably gotten off fairly lightly.

Unfortunately there was a rock opposite the route which intercepted me on the way down. I glanced off that with my rear end, bounced off the belayers shoulder and landed somewhat solidly on my feet.

(Oddly enough my thought when I hit was "this isn't as bad as when I broke my tailbone." Obviously I've fallen too many times this year...)

A jolt had gone through me when I hit the rock and I was in quite a bit of pain right away. I managed to untie myself from the rope and limp over to a park bench where I laid down and felt along my back to

see if anything seemed out of place. That didn't offer much relief so I limped over to Jack's truck and was helped down into one of the seats.

I had some general pain in my lower back and some odd shooting pain coming around the sides towards my belly button. In addition I had a bit of weakness when trying to raise my arms. The pain was bad enough I reluctantly came to the conclusion I should probably go visit the ER.

Of course the guy who left at 2 had been a paramedic. Figures...

After a bit of scrambling to make arrangements to have the gear pulled by someone Jack and Kim drove me to the local High Desert emergency room where they sent out a wheelchair and rolled me into triage still wearing my climbing shoes.

They looked at me very briefly then returned me to the waiting room to sit with Jack and Kim as they said all their beds were currently occupied.

Jack and Kim did their best to keep me company and were even nice enough to bring in some non-painful shoes and help me get out of the climbing booties.



Sadly I was having a bit less fun.



It was painful to sit and it only got worse over the next two hours I had to wait before they could get an open cot for me to lay down. Apparently Sunday night after Thanksgiving is a busy time if you're homeless and / or possibly using mind altering substances.

Not to say there was anything wrong with the guy sitting across from us but he did seem to be twitching an awful lot and I sure couldn't see the invisible bugs that seemed to be plaguing him. At one point he did wake up and wander over to the vending machine which seemed to perplex him in its instance on storing food behind a glass barrier.

When I was eventually let into the back and given a cot the big drama seemed to be centered around a homeless guy living out of his van who had a variety of issues including diabetes and a sore on his rear end that would have to be lanced and packed. He was a bit on the loud side.

The nurse practitioner eventually came by and said the xrays they took earlier didn't show any bone damage and that I'd likely bruised my gluteal muscles. Apparently the good news was they are rather big and so can take an impact but on the downside when they get bruised they hurt like hell. She said the pain would be worse the following day and gave me a prescription for painkillers.

Hey, my old friend Percocet.

She disappeared for what seemed like a long time and just as I was about ready to try and limp out the door on my own a small Indian lady came into my partition and said she was going to give me a morphine shot before discharging. The pain was still rather bad so I agreed readily to lay back down. She warned me that it was going to hurt.

New policy, I now believe everything that small orderlies with large needles tell me.

The shot was in my hip and actually hurt so much I forgot about my back for several seconds. Not a small accomplishment. Those "fortunate" enough to talk to me within the next 30 minutes before I drifted off to lala land can attest I was quite upset about how much the butt shot hurt.

I managed to limp back to the car on my own now that I knew it was just pain and not doing permanent damage. After a few phone calls I don't really recall anything from the 2+ hour drive home other than vaguely limping up the stairs at my apartment.

So, in the end I managed 9 local HPS peaks (and made my 100 HPS Peaks goal), 1 6th class DPS peak (supposedly the most technically difficult on that list), most of a day of climbing, one ER visit, and another contusion to my tailbone. Not too bad for a holiday weekend.

I was only down for a week this time. I wasn't able to fly out to Boise the following week due to the pain and had to cancel out of a desert trip I was supposed to attend the following weekend. The weekend after that I was back out leading Edgar and Mitchell with Paul Garry only a bit worse for the wear.